experiments. Is that the choice forced on us by Bell's theorem? Or is there some weird third thing? It's possible that the roulette wheel selector wasn't truly random, that the roulette balls knew what roulette wheels they would enter in advance. This kind of conspiracy between the roulette wheels and the roulette balls could account for the results that Fatima and Gillian saw. But translate that into real physics, and it starts to look problematic: a conspiracy between photons and polarizers sounds far-fetched, to say the least. What if a human experimenter is deliberately selecting which polarizer to use each time? How could the photons know in advance? We like to think that we are freely choosing the conditions of our experiments—and, even if that's an illusion, the idea that the photons somehow have all our actions pre-encoded within them is difficult to imagine. But technically, this kind of "superdeterminism" may be a logically possible option for escaping Bell's theorem, and a small handful of physicists do work on fleshing out this kind of theory (though there are concerns about whether such a vast natural "conspiracy" would make it impossible to do science in the first place).

Is there anything else? Are there any other ways out of Bell's remarkable theorem? Many books and papers claim that there is another assumption in Bell's proof, that of hidden variables. Don't assume that there are any hidden instructions in the roulette balls at all, the argument goes, and Bell's theorem has no force. But this isn't correct. We didn't assume that there were any instructions in the roulette balls, at least not at the start of the proof. Instead, we merely assumed locality, and this inevitably led us to the conclusion that there must be instructions in the roulette balls, in order to account for the perfect match between Gillian's results and Fatima's when they were both using the same roulette wheels. If this sounds familiar, that's because it's simply the EPR argument. If pairs of roulette balls always land on the same color, then either they're sharing instruction sets from the start, or they're somehow communicating faster than light once they reach their destinations. There was no assumption of hidden variables—there was merely an assumption of locality, and the behavior of the roulette balls forced us to consider hidden variables. "It is remarkably difficult to get this point across: that [hidden variables are] not a *presupposition* of the analysis," Bell complained fifteen years after his theorem was first published. "My own first paper on this subject [Bell's